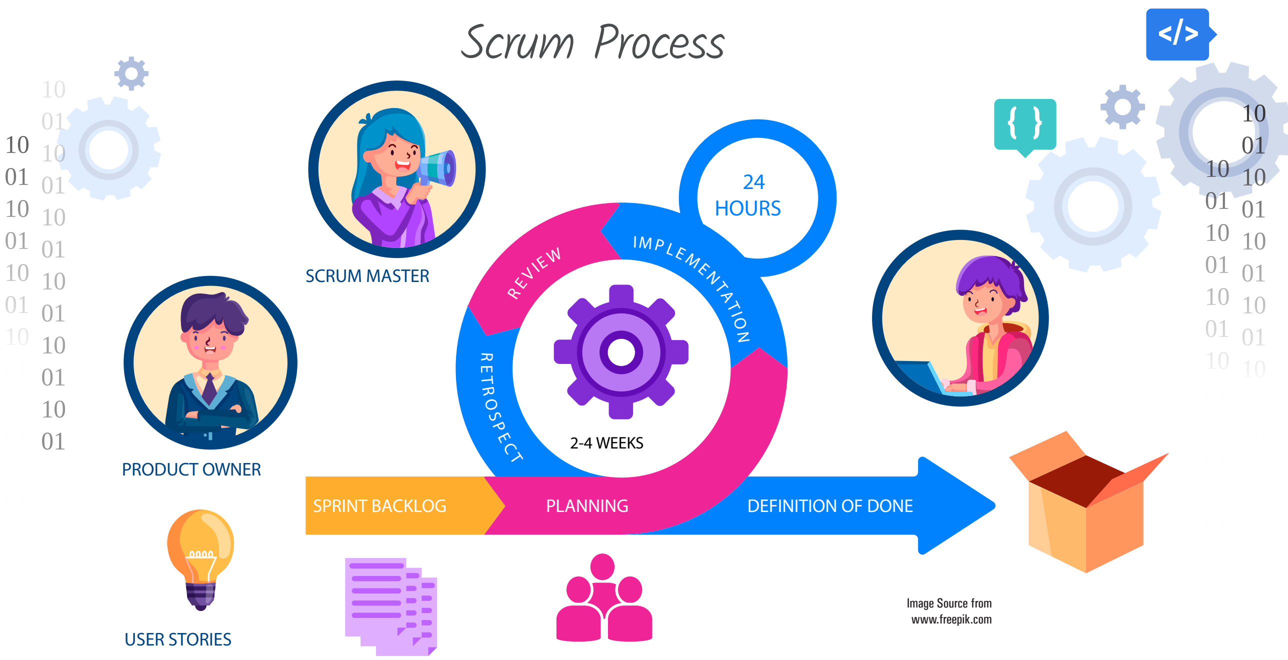
Simplifying Software Development with Scrum Tools

In the first part of this series of articles, we looked at open source desktop project management tools like MS Project. Part 2 discussed project servers like MS Project Server. In this third part, we will look at agile/Scrum software project management tools like Taiga and Tuleap. These open source solutions assist in keeping all the software team members on the same page, whether they are working in the office, from home, or offshore.



Software development is different from, say, building a house. A building can be designed by the architect and final approval given by the customer. The builder can prepare a work breakdown structure (WBS) consisting of all the tasks needed to complete the project and draw a Gantt chart based on this approved design. Software development, on the other hand, is different. Customers are able to say precisely what they want only when they see a feature being demonstrated to them interactively, or even more likely, when a functioning initial version of the application is delivered to them. Documenting requirements and attaching them to a contract leads to many change requests as the project progresses. These change requests are so pervasive that they have acquired a name — 'scope creep'. Scope creep is well known as the number one cause of software project failures.

Of course, some changes in software are easy to make as against in a building. However, technology tends to change very fast. If software development projects take a deterministic approach, such creeping change requests tend to torpedo the original contracted scope of the work. It has been found that an empirical approach with an 'inspect and adapt' cycle results in more successful outcomes for software development projects. These empirical approaches fall under the umbrella of agile software development. Among these, Scrum is the leading agile software development framework.